

The Washington Post

Prices may vary in areas outside metropolitan Washington.

SU V1 V2 V3 V4



Rain 63/60 • Tomorrow: T-storm 77/65 B6

Democracy Dies in Darkness

WEDNESDAY, MAY 28, 2025 • \$4

DOJ asserts wide scope for Jan. 6 pardons

Judges repeatedly reject claim that clemency applies to other charges

BY TOM JACKMAN

At least 10 defendants accused of other crimes when the FBI came to search their homes after the Jan. 6, 2021, Capitol riot have invoked the pardon issued by President Donald Trump to claim that his order also clears them of the secondary charges, and in most of those cases federal prosecutors have joined with the defendants.

But on four occasions recently, federal judges have said no, disagreeing even as the Justice Department argued in favor of broadly applying the president's pardon. In strongly worded opinions, federal judges in Washington and Baltimore have refused to grant dismissals, describing the government's requests as "unreasonable" and "acting in bad faith."

And when one defendant appealed the Washington judge's ruling, the federal D.C. appeals court also rejected him, saying the Trump pardon "does not cover offenses wholly independent of events at the Capitol on January 6, even if uncovered during investigation of January 6 offenses."

Prosecutors do not often side with defendants to challenge federal convictions. But in seven cases testing the bounds of Trump's pardon order, the Justice Department has taken part in the

SEE PARDONS ON A9

Ex-sheriff pardoned: Trump blames Biden for Va. conviction. B1

Trump ups his verbal attacks on Moscow

President floats idea of additional sanctions as chances of ceasefire dim

BY MICHAEL BIRNBAUM AND MARTINE POWERS

President Donald Trump lashed out at the Kremlin on Tuesday for its unwillingness to negotiate a ceasefire with Ukraine as he continued to consider increased sanctions against Russia, an escalation from his previously friendly tone toward Vladimir Putin that came as the president appeared to grow gloomier about his ability to broker peace in Ukraine.

In perhaps his harshest rhetoric yet against Putin, Trump declared that Putin is "playing with fire" — a reference to Russia's escalating bombardment of Ukraine in recent days despite the U.S. president's efforts to broker a peace agreement between Kyiv and Moscow.

Trump has offered mixed messages about Putin, oscillating between praise of a leader with whom he has said he believes he can do business and frustration about his inability to bring Russia

SEE PUTIN ON A12

Eastern Ukraine: Region braces for Russian summer offensive. A12



PHOTOS BY RORY DOYLE/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

La. town sees ICE facility as a boon

The 21st century has been tough here in timber country, especially in the small town of Winnfield. Sawmills automated and jobs disappeared. An interstate extension bypassed the area. The population fell by nearly a third. Downtown storefronts emptied.

One positive: the low-slung brick complex, with razor-wire-topped fencing and a white-steeped chapel, that sprawls southwest of town amid a forest of longleaf and loblolly pines.

Six years ago, U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement took over this prison, contracted with the sheriff and began detaining migrants there. With them came well-paying positions, plus an infusion of money for Winn Parish's jail, school resource officers and other services.

These days, Winn Correctional Center's 1,600 beds make it the largest ICE detention center in this deep-red state and one of the

Gulf Coast detention center brings a surge of jobs and services to 'dying community'

BY MOLLY HENNESSY-FISKE
IN WINNFIELD, LA.



TOP: Forest surrounds Winnfield, Louisiana, once buoyed by the local timber industry. ABOVE: Friends gather for their daily coffee at Country Girl truck stop in Winnfield.

largest in the country. With President Donald Trump's hard deportation push, its beds are staying occupied.

The economic benefits of detention, in a rural parish where about a quarter of residents live in poverty, have muted criticism of the president's immigration policies. Many take more issue with outsiders who accuse the administration of trying to isolate detainees by sending them to such a remote spot — in a swath of the Gulf Coast known as "detention alley" because it's home to 14 of the country's 20 largest immigration detention centers.

"Like Louisiana is so terrible," said Terry Warden, a retired Trump supporter who years ago moved from Southern California for political reasons. "Yeah, we've got gators. And we've got lawyers. We're not Gitmo."

ICE detainee buses are now as common a sight as lumber trucks

SEE WINNFIELD ON A6

'Fearful, paranoid, demoralized': VA staffers brace for deep cuts

BY MERYL KORNFIELD AND LISA REIN

Morale is plummeting inside the Department of Veterans Affairs as tens of thousands of employees prepare for deep staffing cuts, raising alarms among staffers, veterans and advocates who

fear the reductions would severely damage care and benefits for millions of the nation's former service members.

VA Secretary Douglas A. Collins has signaled plans to shrink the agency's workforce by 15 percent — or about 83,000 employees. Although agency officials in-

sist front-line health-care workers and claims processors will be spared, the vague and shifting details of the Trump administration's downsizing plan have only fueled anxiety and speculation within VA's massive workforce.

The uncertainty is already taking a toll.

Thousands of employees across VA's health and benefits systems have opted for early retirement in two waves, which would pay them through Sept. 30 to get them to leave, according to internal data reviewed by The Washington Post. Many of these employees said they are opting to

leave out of fear that they would be laid off anyway.

Many Democrats have already seized on President Donald Trump's VA cuts as damaging to

SEE VA ON A5

Brain drain?: Amid funding losses, scientists look at going abroad. A8



RICKY CARIOTI/THE WASHINGTON POST

Pete Hegseth, seen during a January hearing on his nomination to serve as defense secretary, has struggled to impose order on his own staff, according to current and former defense officials.

Within Hegseth's circle, a 'cold war' endures

Even after a purge, personality conflicts and inexperience are driving dysfunction, insiders say

BY DAN LAMOTHE

An enduring rift among Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth's cadre of senior advisers has divided the Pentagon's front office and fueled internal speculation about his long-term viability in the Cabinet post after several episodes that attracted White House scrutiny, according to numerous people familiar with the matter.

The conflict within Hegseth's inner circle persists even after he purged several political appointees in April and after attempts to portray a sense of unity among his remaining brain trust. His claims,

however, are belied by continued behind-the-scenes dysfunction, brought on by unresolved personality conflicts, inexperience, vacancies in key leadership roles and a steady-state paranoia over what political crisis could emerge next, current and former officials said. They described the situation on the condition of anonymity because of its sensitivity and fear of retaliation.

"There's a cold war that exists in between flash points," said one person, recounting numerous instances when tempers have flared among key figures on the

SEE HEGSETH ON A4

IN THE NEWS

Harvard hit again The White House directed federal agencies to end or transition contracts, a move that the school's president said will hurt research innovation. A9

Business-friendly budget D.C. Mayor Muriel E. Bowser unveiled a \$21.8 billion spending plan that seeks to invest in growth. B1

THE NATION
Texas moved closer to requiring public schools to display the Ten Commandments. A3
The Supreme Court declined to stop the transfer of a Native site in Arizona for mining. A7

THE WORLD
British police, usually tight-lipped, quickly addressed the race of a suspect in a car attack. A10
Women's cancer deaths in some nations rose along with temperatures, a study found. A11

THE ECONOMY
Community agencies are struggling after 32,000 AmeriCorps service workers were terminated as part of DOGE-led cuts. A13
SpaceX lost another Starship on a test flight after two earlier failures, posing challenges to Elon Musk's vision. A14

THE REGION
The FBI will investigate the leak of a draft of the decision overturning *Roe v. Wade* and the planting of pipe bombs in D.C., a bureau official said. B1
A ceremony honoring Vietnam War veterans has been moved because of the Army's 250th birthday celebration. B1

SPORTS
Half of all D.C.-area adults now "like" or "love" the Washington Commanders' name, up from 34 percent a year ago, a poll found. D1

FOOD
Experts help debunk five myths about food expiration dates and sell-by labels. E1

BUSINESS NEWS.....A13
COMICS.....C5
OBITUARIES.....B4
OPINION PAGES.....A15
TELEVISION.....C4
WORLD NEWS.....A10

CONTENT © 2025
The Washington Post
Year 148, No. 54230

